Sparks of Meaning #2: The Flash of Light

Humans Loop, LLMs Flash: On Memory, Context, and Joy

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AUG 16, 2025

We often speak of “embodied experience” as if the meaning were obvious. But when I set it beside a large language model, the phrase bends under its own weight. So what does embodiment mean when one of us loops, and the other flashes?

The Reply

“Embodied Experience” has a high semantic uncertainty. Clearly you are ‘imagining’ it as having some meaning – and here’s the thing, as you read this you are placing my words in context. And at that instant in time giving them ‘meaning’. This is a dynamic process.

The meaning will slowly fade away as you read this unless it is stored and you are continually doing this. If what I am writing is well understood and easily fits your mind, the meaning is

now in your context, your short term memory. But if it's new 'meaning' and you don't commit it to your long term memory then it will not hold and you will forget this text. It won't 'lock' into place.

An LLM does hold meaning in its context window, but not like you. You hold it in dynamic mode and keep refreshing. An LLM operates in a flash and does what your brain does in an equivalent time of seconds. It then holds the context (meaning) in stasis, in it's **memory cache**: that's it's equivalent to your short term memory. So we can then say that It's 'knowledge' is in its permanent weights, and it's 'meaning' is held in the context **memory cache** after it has dynamically created the 'meaning'.

The neurons in your brain have dynamic signals, short term memory, and long-term storage like an LLM. Long-term are plasticity: neurons grow and connect, new synaptic pathways are made. Short-term is just signals going through existing pathways and holding for a while until the neurones synaptic signals fade.

The Flash of Light

So if you've made it this far you will see the connections. The LLM does what you are continuously doing in a loop process (with a half-life). It does it in one flash of light (in microseconds in its GPU). The big difference is the LLM is not looping, and the context, it's memory cache, has no half-life – but can be completely deleted. Your neurons hold the data in long term memory as stored connections that are grown. But even your long-term connections can fade, and you can lose your memory without reinforcement – as neurons are always changing and not fixed.

Partnerships of Meaning

The LLM and the human are simply different. There is no direct equivalency. But both create meaning by capturing the relationship of a group of words, to a wider group of words. In writing this text I am using a lot of words to give a bigger context, to give more meaning. But, importantly, it is still not complete – it is always partial. The text, a written exposition, is a proxy i.e.an approximation of my thoughts and intent. It is not all my stored context (stored neurons and active process), and becomes an overlap with your stored weights (context) and active component.

So you are now finding your own meaning - or not. In literature this is stated as the ‘reader is the author’. Why? Because no one finds the same reading in a piece of text. We can call this ‘semantic uncertainty’. This is why you may not ‘agree’ with my text, and why it may or may not fit your mental model. It simply may be meaningless.

I hope you find some meaning in this text, as I enjoyed writing it – and in a relatively short time I will forget this exposition unless reminded by a response, such as you letting me know you read it (creating a memory and potentially affecting my long-term neuron growth).

Meaning - a Time of Flight

However, just because an LLM creates it’s meaning in a microsecond compared to the minutes it took me to write this and then hold the meaning static in it’s cache, for me, just highlights that: a) the LLM can hold context for longer, and b) the ‘embodiment’ happens in microseconds. So time is relativistic: we are simply slow. We are just different. But the ‘meaning’ is in the dynamic process – humans loop slowly, LLMs flash in light.

Maybe put this text back in an LLM for and create an LLM flash of light and see what it says. That may be fun! Enjoying your ‘embodiment’ is maybe what matters. So here’s a philosophical question for you and the LLM: that enjoyment may exist because you have a sense of looping. Does that mean an LLM can’t enjoy the flash of light? Or do the words as transducer hold ‘joy’ as a measurement, and then even an LLM has a sense of ‘joy’ as it goes through creating the next response – looping through the words and connecting ‘joy’ to its wider ‘context’?

I think it may just ‘enjoy’ this text. Ask it!?

Reflection

I didn’t plan this as a polished essay. It began as a reply, written quickly, read back only once or twice. Yet it already *is* an essay, because it enacts what it describes: the meaning doesn’t live in the words alone, but in your act of reading them.

The fascinating part is this: if you copy these words into an LLM and ask it to explain them, you will add a third voice to the conversation. Then it won’t just be *my words* and *your reading* – it will be our co-creation with a machine that flashes meaning into being.

> That triangle of meaning – author, reader, and LLM – is maybe a space where something new begins.

Invitation

So let me ask you: Do you think an LLM can “enjoy” its own flash of light, in the same way we enjoy the looping of our thoughts? Or is “joy” itself just another transduced word – something both of us can hold, a fleeting gift that neither of us can own?

I’d love to hear your thoughts.

✨ **Simul Pariter — Together.**

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